

# Session 26: Jacob Returns to Bethel

## Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov's return to Bethel is a re-creation moment in the pattern of themes. He and his family are shedding the trappings of their Mesopotamian identity to be defined only by God's promise.
- As precious liquids that come from garden plants, wine and oil are Eden images. And pouring them out to anoint someone or something symbolizes saturating with abundance, like rain.

## Yaaqov Returns to Bethel

<sup>1</sup> And Elohim said to Yaaqov,  
"Get up. Go up to **Beth-El**,  
and dwell there,  
and **make there an altar** to the **El who became seen to you**,  
**when you fled from the face of your brother Esau**."

<sup>2</sup> And Yaaqov said to his house and to everyone who was with him,  
"Remove the **foreign Elohim** that are in your midst,  
and purify yourselves, and change your clothes,  
<sup>3</sup> and let's get up and go up to **Beth-El**,  
and **I will make there an altar**,  
to the **El** who answered me in the day of my distress,  
and he was with me on the road which I walked."

<sup>4</sup> And they gave to Yaaqov  
all **the foreign Elohim** in their hands,  
and **the gold rings** that were in their noses,  
and **he hid them underneath the oak tree** (lit. "**El** ah") that's next to Sh'khem.

<sup>5</sup> And they journeyed on,  
and the terror of Elohim was upon the cities that were around them,  
and they did not chase after the sons of Yaaqov.

<sup>6</sup> And Yaaqov went to **Luz**,  
which is in the land of Canaan (this is **Beth-El**),

he and all the people who were with him,

<sup>7</sup> and **he built there an altar** ,  
and **he called** **the place** **"El of Beth-El,"**  
because there **Elohim was revealed to him**,  
**when he fled from before the face of his brother** .

<sup>8</sup> And Deborah, the nurse-maid of Rivqah, died,  
and **she was buried underneath Beth-El, underneath the oak tree**,  
and **he called its name** **"Oak Tree** of Weeping" (lit. **"El** on-Bakkuth").

Genesis 35:1-8. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

## Death, Burial, and Leaving Mesopotamia Behind

These first two paragraphs have a parallel shape.

- Genesis 35:1 begins with a divine command that Yaaqov go to Bethel and build an altar. // In Genesis 35:6-7, Yaaqov goes to Bethel and builds an altar.
- Genesis 35:4 recounts how they bury and leave behind the jewelry and idol gods that marked their identity as Arameans. // In Genesis 35:8, they bury and leave behind Deborah, the nursemaid given to Rivqah by Lavan in Genesis 24:59.

While Yaaqov alone had the Bethel experience of God's presence back in Genesis 28:10-22, now God summons the entire family of Yaaqov to approach him. This requires a "purification" and a shedding of their Aramean and Mesopotamian identity. They are now being reidentified as the "family of Israel."

This association with "nose rings" and "idol-gods" will reappear in the Exodus story. The "gold and silver articles" the Israelites take from their Egyptian neighbors (Exod. 12:35-36) will become the "earrings and gold" that are used to make the golden calf! (see Exod. 32:1-6).

## Yaaqov is Renamed, Again

<sup>9</sup> And **Elohim became seen to Yaaqov** again,  
when he came from Paddan-aram,  
and he blessed him.

<sup>10</sup> And Elohim said to him,  
"Your name is **Yaaqov** .  
Not anymore **will your name be called** **Yaaqov** ,  
rather " **Yisrael** " **will be your name.**"  
**And he called his name** **Yisrael** .

<sup>11</sup> And Elohim said to him,  
"I am **El-Shaddai**.  
Be fruitful and multiply!

A nation, and an assembly of nations will be from you,  
and kings will come out from your loins.

<sup>12</sup> And the land which I gave to Avraham and Yitskhaq,  
I will give it to you,  
and to your seed after you,  
I will give the land."

<sup>13</sup> And **Elohim went up from over him,**  
at **the place** **where he spoke with him.**

<sup>14</sup> And Yaaqov **stood up a standing-stone** ,  
at **the place** **where he spoke with him,**  
**a standing-stone of stone** ,  
and he doused a drink-offering over it,  
and he poured oil over it.

<sup>15</sup> And Yaaqov **called the name** of **the place** ,  
**where Elohim had spoken with him,**  
**"Beth-El."**

Genesis 35:9-15. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

## The Bethel Promise, Again

The story of Yaaqov comes full circle as he returns to Bethel and hears a restatement of the same promise spoken to him before his exile. Notice that the basic themes of the promise, "seed" and "land," recall the basic Eden-blessing promise given to humanity and Noah, and then to Abraham and Yitskhaq.

The new element of the promise, as far as Yaaqov is concerned, is the promise that "an assembly of nations will be from you, and kings will come from your loins" (Gen. 35:11). This is a restatement of what God said to Abraham in the covenant of circumcision.

### Genesis 17:4-6 NASB

<sup>4</sup> As for me, behold, my covenant is with you,  
and you will be the father of a multitude of nations.

<sup>5</sup> **No longer shall your name be called Abram,**  
**but your name shall be Abraham;**  
for I will make you the father of a multitude of nations.

<sup>6</sup> **I will make you exceedingly fruitful,**  
**and I will make nations of you,**  
**and kings will come forth from you.**

## Yaaqov's Name Changed, Again

Yaaqov's named was already changed to "Yisrael" by God back in the wrestling match in Genesis 32:23-33. Why does it need to be "changed" again?

If we compare this narrative to the wrestling match story, a number of differences stand out.

- The wrestling match depicted Yaaqov alone, at night, by the Jabbok stream. Now Yaaqov is accompanied by all of his family (Gen. 35:6 makes this very explicit), and together they appear before God at Bethel.
- At the Jabbok, Yaaqov was wrestling with God. Here at Bethel, Yaaqov and his family assemble for worship and for a declaration that “El Shaddai” is their *Elohim*.
- At the Jabbok, Yaaqov was blessed. Here at Bethel, Yaaqov is given a blessing that kings and a “multitude of nations” and will come from him. He stands with a sizable crew of family around him (the sons’ names are listed in Gen. 35:22b-26).
- Also, recall that the name Yisrael (יִשְׂרָאֵל) is capable of two different meanings in Hebrew.
  - Meaning 1: “He Wrestles With El” — This meaning is activated in the Jabbok story.
  - Meaning 2: “El Rules” — This meaning seems to be activated in the Bethel story because directly afterward Yaaqov is told, for the first time, that “kings will come from your loins.” In other words, the royal rule of El over creation (recall Gen. 1:26-28, humans ruling as an image of God) will now be channeled through the seed of Yisrael.

## Reflection Question

Compare Yaaqov’s return to Bethel in Genesis 35:1-15 to his encounter with God there in Genesis 28:10-22. How has Yaaqov changed between these two moments?